molecules which are absorbed by the thickener present in the printed fabric. The water absorbed by the thickener dissolves the dyes or pigments and hence increases the rate of absorption of pigment from thickeners to the fabric. As soon as steaming is done the fabric has to be dried.

3.6.2 Washing Off

The printed fabric after undergoing steaming process contains exhausted thickeners and some printing auxiliaries. If the thickeners used are temporary thickeners, they are removed by washing. Washing is done using cold water. Fabrics are washed with neutral soaps to avoid bleed in water. Rinsing removes the print paste chemicals and unfixed dye molecules. For vat dyed printed fabric, oxidation is carried out first followed by soaping.

Advantages

- Defines the print or design
- Prevents loss of colour
- Avoids spreading of colour beyond the design boundary

Disadvantages

- Expensive process because it requires steam and floor space
- Chances of spoiling the printed fabric due to power cuts etc.

3.7 SUMMARY

Printing is an aesthetic enhancement on fabric. There are various styles of printing namely direct, discharge and resist. In direct style of printing, the dye is directly applied onto the fabric. In discharge style, the fabric is printed on a dyed fabric. In the resist style, the bleached fabric is printed with a substance like wax, rice paste, china clay or chemicals such as acids, alkalis and salts. Different methods of printing include block, screen, stencil, transfer, batik, photo printing etc. Block printing is the ancient method of printing designs using wooden blocks. Roller printing is a machine printing, which produces over 4000 yards of fabric per hour. Stencil printing is done with the help of cardboard, wood, metal or plastic sheets with marker pens or pencils. Transfer printing refers to shifting of a design from one surface to the other. Batik printing is a hand printing method in which designs are made using wax. In Photo printing, the fabric is coated with a chemical sensitive to light and photographs are printed on fabrics to produce designs. The printed fabrics undergo after treatment processes such as drying, steaming and washing to enhance dye fixation and remove the unfixed dyes and chemicals.

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